

One ballot, 120 seats

Facilitator notes | 15 minutes | Prepared 2026-10-05

For: Readers new to Israeli elections; pairs or a small discussion group.

Before you start: No prior knowledge. A browser is useful for the linked guides but not required for the exercise.

Learning objectives

- Explain the 3.25% threshold and what happens below it.
- Distinguish an electoral list from a bloc.
- Explain why the largest list does not automatically form a government.

Set up and pace

Give learners the sheet. Read the opening aloud, work in pairs on the fictional ballot, then invite explanations rather than a show of hands. Allow 3 minutes to read, 5 for the ballot, 4 for partner explanations and 3 for a closing question.

Keep the three objectives visible. Let participants skip a question. A phone is enough to open the guides; the printed sheet supplies the core facts.

Answer notes

A, B and C pass; D does not. D receives no seats, and its votes are not transferred to an ally. Passing lists account for 97% of the valid vote. Their relative shares form the seat-allocation pool; exact whole-seat allocation also uses the Bader-Ofer rules.

Being largest does not identify which lists will cooperate, the proposed prime minister, confidence support or policy conditions. The builder's seat target and recorded commitments are separate evidence.

An electoral list is a ballot choice and may include constituent parties. A bloc is a grouping for analysis. A 61-seat grouping has an absolute majority; do not turn this into a universal statement about every confidence vote.

National eligibility depends on citizenship and legal conditions. Residents and people affected by decisions are not one legal category. The Who votes guide distinguishes Palestinian citizens, East Jerusalem permanent residents and Palestinians in the occupied West Bank and Gaza.

Questions worth pursuing

Ask: What would make an apparently simple arithmetic answer misleading? Which facts are legal rules, which are current political commitments, and which are our hypothetical assumptions?

If participants ask for today's numbers, open the polls rather than reading an old number from a slide. Record the publication date and the average's method before comparing it with an individual poll.

Check understanding and adapt

Before finishing, ask two people to explain the threshold, list/bloc distinction and largest-list point in their own words. Correct misconceptions with the guide evidence rather than partisan examples.

For a 30-minute session, add the five-minute guided route and compare two party profiles. For remote teaching, share the accessible HTML sheet and invite spoken or typed responses. Treat unfamiliar-reader feedback as evidence for improving the lesson.

Sources and next steps

From votes to seats - source links and method - Facts checked October 5, 2026

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/seats>

Who votes - citizenship, residency and geography - See the guide's evidence dates

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/who-votes>

Forming a government - legal process - See the guide's evidence dates

<https://www.israelielection.org/how-it-works/forming-a-government>

Israel Democracy Institute - the electoral system - March 16, 2026

<https://en.idi.org.il/articles/63750>

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